

The Little Lantern That Was Afraid to Shine

Every evening, when the sun disappeared behind the hills, the village of Willowbrook lit its lanterns.

Every lantern except one.

Her name was **Lumi**.

Lumi lived in a little wooden house beside the village path. She was small, round, and had a golden glass window.

But Lumi had a secret.

She was afraid to shine.

"What if my light isn't bright enough?" she whispered whenever the other lanterns began glowing.

So she stayed dark.

One evening, a little boy named Eli was walking home when the wind suddenly blew out his candle.

The path became completely dark.

Eli stopped.

He couldn't see the bridge.

He couldn't see the trees.

And he couldn't see the way home.

"Hello?" he called.

No answer.

Then, from a small wooden house beside the path, came a tiny glow.

Lumi had opened her window.

Her light wasn't bright.

It didn't reach very far.

But it reached Eli.

"Oh!" Eli smiled. "There you are."

Lumi trembled.

"I'm sorry," she whispered. "I'm not very bright."

Eli looked at her little golden light.

"You don't have to light the whole village," he said. "You just have to help me see the next step."

So Lumi shone a little brighter.

One step.

Then another.

Soon, Eli reached the bridge.

But the wind blew harder.

Lumi's little flame flickered.

"I can't do this," she cried.

Then something surprising happened.

One of the big lanterns at the village gate saw Lumi struggling.

It shone toward her.

Then another lantern joined.

Then another.

Before long, the whole path was glowing.

Lumi looked around in amazement.

"You're all helping me?"

The old lantern at the gate smiled.

"Of course. Light was never meant to be kept to itself."

Together, they guided Eli safely home.

That night, Lumi discovered something she had never understood before.

She didn't need to be the brightest lantern.

She only needed to be willing to shine.

And sometimes, **one small light is enough to help someone find their way.**

Gentle lesson

You don't have to be the biggest, strongest, or brightest to make a difference. A small act of courage or kindness can become a light for someone else.